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Research

dbDataInsights Geopolitics Survey

UK Politics: Perspectives on leadership transition and key priorities

June 2026

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IMPORTANT RESEARCH DISCLOSURES LOCATED IN APPENDIX 1.

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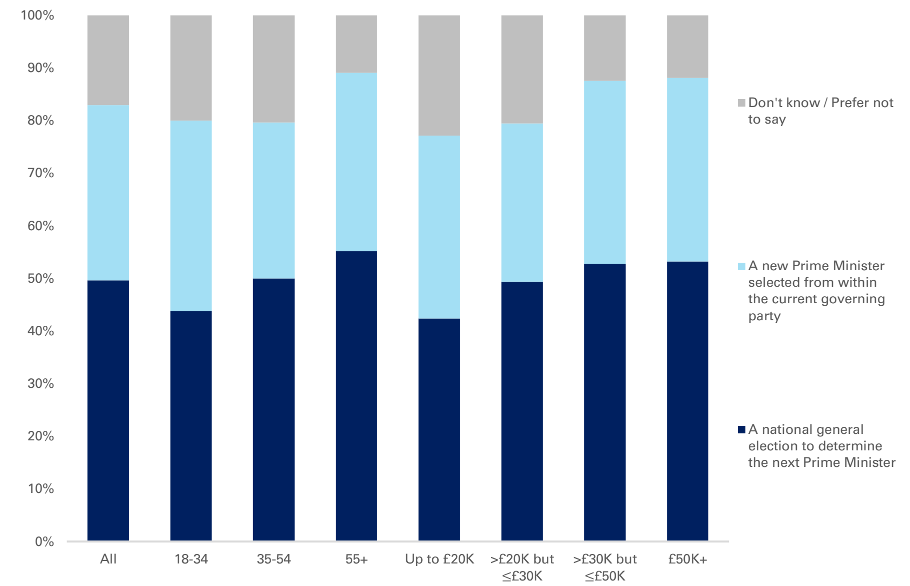
Population would prefer election to determine the next Prime Minister

– Prime Minister Starmer's administration is currently navigating a complex political landscape, contending with economic pressures, the implementation of key policy initiatives, and recent instances of political controversy. In addition, Labour saw poor results in the latest local elections. By mid-May, ~100 Labour MPs had called on PM Starmer to resign or set a departure timetable – though 111 backbenchers signed a letter opposing a leadership challenge. Speculation around the Prime Minister's position remains, with rival Andy Burnham running to return to Westminster as part of the Makerfield by-election.

– Our dbDataInsights survey suggests that voters are considering the potential for significant political change and its implications. **In a scenario where the Labour Party were to elect a new successor**, a notable **50% of respondents expressed a preference for a national general election** to determine the next Prime Minister, rather than an internal selection process.

– This sentiment is particularly salient as PM Starmer is currently only one of the last five PMs to have entered Downing Street as a result of a general election victory. The preference for broader electoral participation is observed to be strongest among the oldest age cohort, indicating a desire for a more direct public mandate in future leadership changes.

UK participants were asked: if the UK Prime Minister did change soon, which of the following would you most prefer: a new PM selected from within the governing party or a general election?



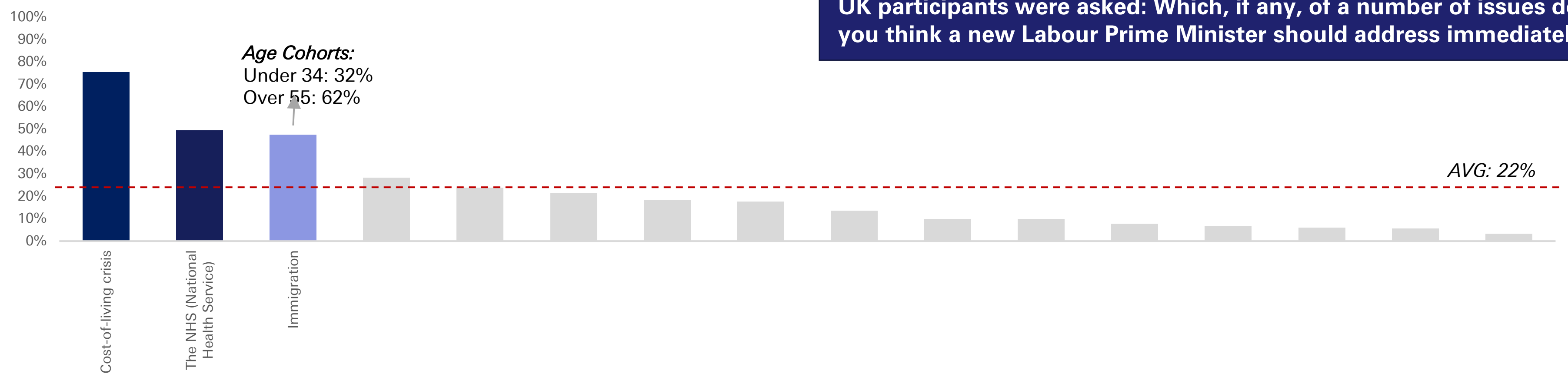
Methodology

These results are derived from a monthly online nationally representative survey. We survey ~550 respondents in European countries and the UK, and ~650 respondents in the US. Our protocol ensures proportional representation across key demographics such as age, income, location, and gender to accurately reflect population diversity. Participants are restricted from taking the survey more than once every six months. The geopolitics questions are integrated into a larger monthly survey conducted by the dbDataInsights team.

Source: dbDataInsights
Responses collected in May 2026 from an Online Nationally Representative sample of ~650 US respondents.

Cost of living an overwhelming concern for Britains

UK participants were asked: Which, if any, of a number of issues do you think a new Labour Prime Minister should address immediately?



- Cost-of-living concerns are seen as the key priority to be tackled by any new Prime Minister. This is particularly salient given the volatile global environment, where escalating trade tensions, persistent tariff pressures, and broader geopolitical uncertainty fuel inflationary pressures on essential goods and services (namely, energy and food). Such external factors inevitably translate into significant impacts on household purchasing power and overall consumer sentiment domestically.

- This is reflected in the survey data, with an overwhelming **75% of respondents identifying the "cost-of-living crisis"** as the most critical immediate issue for a new Labour Prime Minister. The consistently high salience of this figure across all demographic groups underscores its importance. Addressing it would be a foundational priority for any incoming government seeking broad public support.

- Beyond economic pressures, the **National Health Service** also stands out as a significant immediate focus, identified by 49% of respondents – a reflection of an ageing society. This highlights a widespread public expectation that the health service requires urgent attention and resources beyond the multi-billion-pound investment delivered thus far.

- Furthermore, demographic-specific priorities are evident within the survey results. A notable **62% of the oldest age cohort surveyed identified immigration** as a key issue requiring the attention of any incoming Prime Minister.

Source: dbDataInsights
Responses collected in May 2026 from an online nationally representative sample of ~550 respondents in European countries and the UK, and ~650 in the US. See slide 1 for further information.

Focus on unity through decisiveness

- 40% of respondents believe a new Labour Prime Minister should primarily concentrate on **fostering national unity**. This figure rises slightly to 44% among those who anticipate a stronger and more decisive leadership approach, suggesting a segment of the electorate desires clear and firm direction in navigating national challenges.
- Approximately 42% of respondents anticipate that a new Labour Prime Minister would introduce **a fresh or innovative vision for the country.** This sentiment is particularly pronounced among higher-income demographics, with 61% of those earning over £50,000 annually expressing confidence in such a prospect.
- This suggests that while there is a general appetite for new ideas, specific segments of the electorate, particularly those with higher incomes, may hold stronger hopes for transformative policy directions under a new Labour leader.
- "Faith" in a new leader appears to diminish with age, suggesting younger cohorts are more optimistic about a fresh start.

UK participants were asked: How likely or unlikely do you think it is that a new Labour Prime Minister would focus on national unity/consensus-building, have a fresh/innovative vision for the country, and/or be a stronger/more decisive Prime Minister?

Source: dbDataInsights
Responses collected in May 2026 from an online nationally representative sample of ~550 respondents in European countries and the UK, and ~650 in the US. See slide 1 for further information.

Expectations for UK's international standing and economic future

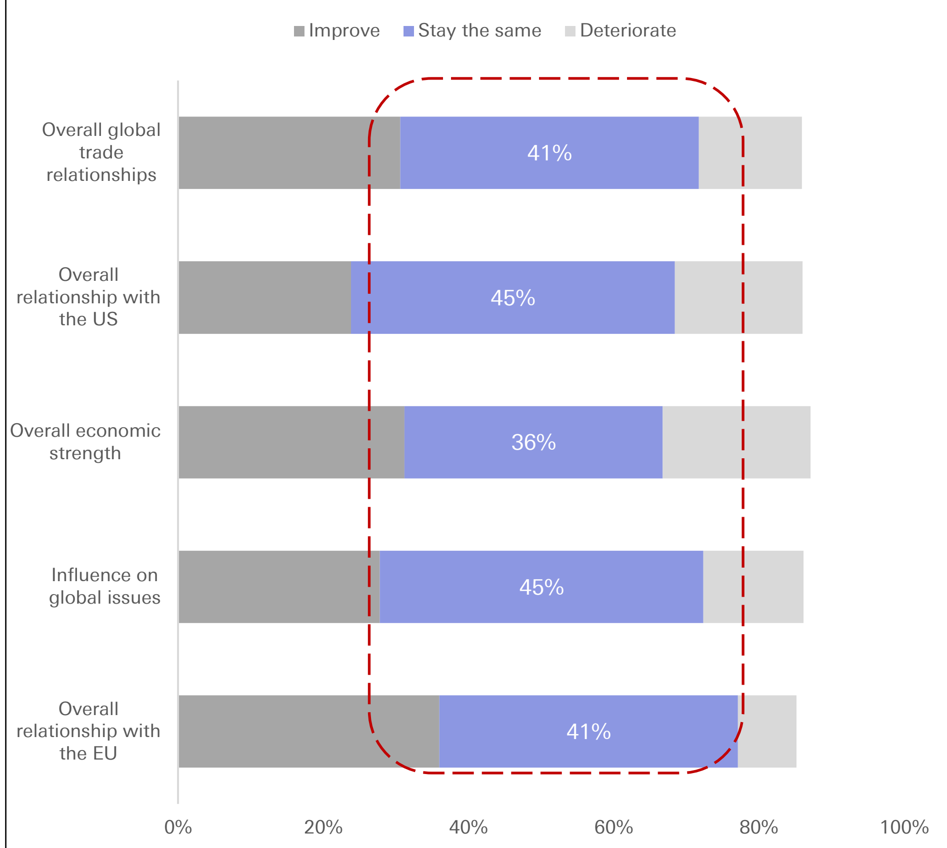
– The data points to a public mood that is guarded, indicating that any new Prime Minister would face the challenge of not only delivering tangible improvements but also shifting perceptions about the nation's global trajectory.

– 45% of respondents **expect the UK's influence on global issues and the UK's relationship with the US to remain unchanged** under a new Prime Minister. Only 28% and 24%, respectively, foresee improvement. This could indicate a perception that these areas are particularly entrenched or less amenable to rapid positive change, regardless of a new Prime Minister's efforts.

– In every category, a plurality of respondents anticipates that current conditions will "stay the same“, which suggests a prevailing sentiment of cautious realism, or perhaps a lack of strong optimism for immediate positive shifts across critical areas such as international relations, global influence, and economic performance.

– While expectations that "economic strength" and "global trade relationships" would "stay the same" are also prominent (36% and 41%, respectively), a somewhat higher proportion still hopes for improvement (31% in both cases), suggesting slightly more fluidity or a greater desire for change in these economically relevant domains.

UK participants were asked: Under the new Labour Prime Minister, do you think the following would improve, stay the same, deteriorate or don't know: overall relationship with the EU, influence on global issues, overall economic strength, overall relationship with the US, and overall global trade relationships?



Source: dbDataInsights
Responses collected in May 2026 from an online nationally representative sample of ~550 respondents in European countries and the UK, and ~650 in the US. See slide 1 for further information.

Appendix 1

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